



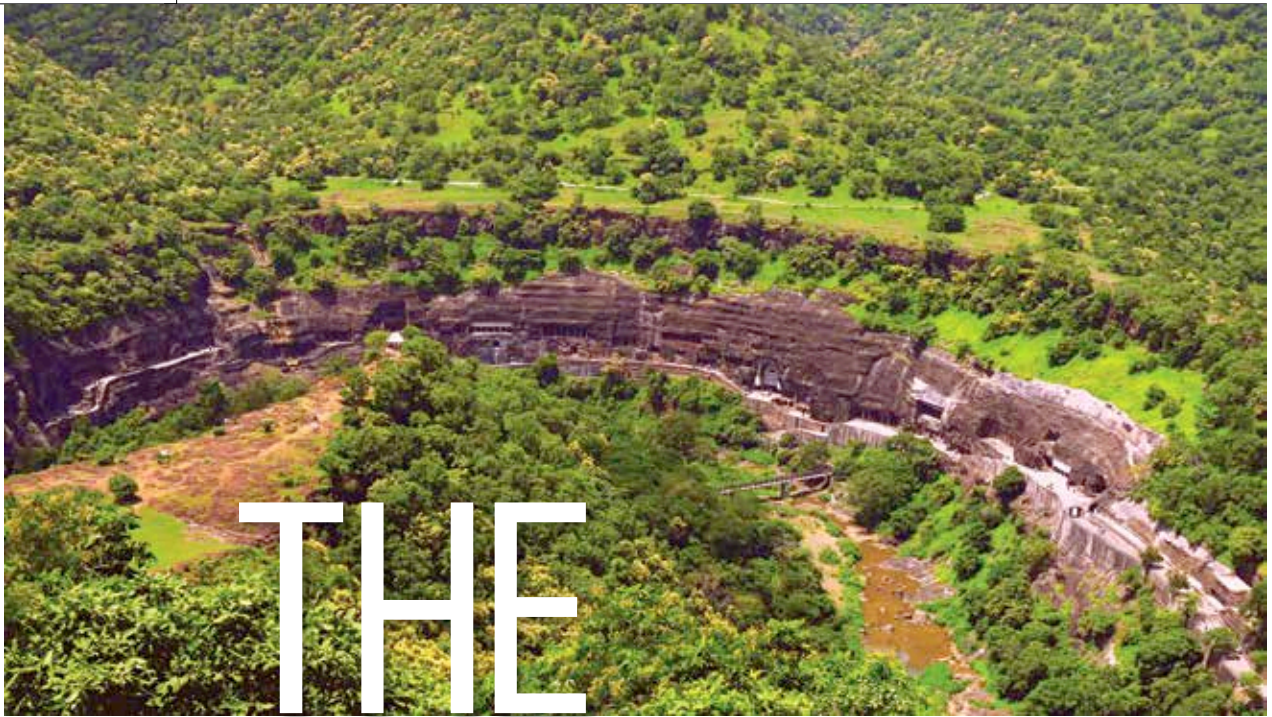
Snake bites even with mouth closed

New species of stiletto snake capable of sideways strikes discovered in West Africa.
<https://digit.in/apr19-17>



Mammoth DNA awakens for a bit

Mammoth cells recently "woken up" for short time inside mouse eggs, not even close to successful cloning. <https://digit.in/apr19-18>



Credit: Jayesh Paranjape

THE DECCAN TRAPS

Ancient lava flows formed one of the largest known volcanic features on Earth, in the northwest part of the Deccan Plateau

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igh school geography teaches us that there are three kinds of rocks. Igneous, metamorphic and

sedimentary. Igneous rocks are volcanic in origin, sedimentary rocks are built up over time by deposition of particles, and metamorphic rocks are

transformed by processes of heat and pressure. We will not blame you if you are nodding off to sleep already, as high school geography can be incredibly boring – at least in the textbooks.

If you trek up into the Sahyadris, and look at layers upon layers of striated igneous rocks, it is an awe-inspiring spectacle. Kalsubai, the highest peak in Maharashtra is easily accessible because of ladders, and offers a breathtaking view of the three peaks of Alang, Madan and Kulang, just about

the toughest treks in the region. Mahabaleshwar also has good views, and the surrounding mountains are made up of massive ancient volcanic flows. The Ajanta-Ellora caves are ancient Buddhist monuments, carved directly and painstakingly into the volcanic rocks, over a period of at least seven centuries. There are natural lines passing through some of the statues in these caves, which are layers formed by different volcanic flows.

All of these places are part of what is known as the Deccan Traps, a vast region in west-central India that are the remains of ancient volcanic flows. There are Deccan rocks on the seafloor in the Arabian Sea. Dulhe, Amravati, Nanded, Latur, Solapur, Sangli and Kolhapur together form a rough boundary for the traps, with the north west part of the Deccan Plateau in the middle. The plateau, referred to as the Precambrian Indian shield by geologists, is a fragment of the supercontinent known as Gondwanaland, and one of the most ancient and stable land masses in the world.

Eastwards, there are also some Deccan rocks in Saurashtra and Kachchh. In Rajasthan and Madhya Pradesh, the fertile Malwa Plateau is an extension of the Deccan traps, called the Manda-